

18 Tips To Pass Automated Screening Resume Software

Indeed Editorial Team | Updated December 11, 2025

Source: indeed.com/career-advice/resumes-cover-letters/automated-screening-resume

What is automated resume screening?

Automated resume screening (ATS) is a type of software used by recruiters, human resource professionals and others involved in the hiring process. ATS programs categorize your resume into different sections. These categories may vary depending on the company that uses them but typically include work experiences, skills, educational background and contact information. The ATS software then searches for specific keywords and phrases related to the position and company you're applying to.

Companies may use ATS software to review resumes received through email, online portals or other digital means. Larger companies with more employees are more likely to use ATS software.

Why do companies use automated screening software?

Companies use automated screening software to quickly review a large number of resumes. Some companies receive hundreds or even thousands of resumes for each position they advertise. Hiring managers often find it difficult to read and review so many resumes, especially since they usually recruit for more than one position at a time. ATS software helps recruiters and other professionals find qualified candidates faster. With ATS software, employers can optimize their recruiting process and fill positions more quickly.

18 Tips for Writing a Resume That Passes Automated Screening

1. Use keywords

Include keywords throughout your resume. Keywords are words or phrases that describe your qualifications for a specific position. They vary depending on the job title, required experience, company and other factors. The best way to identify the most appropriate keywords for a specific position is to carefully analyze the job description. Look for specific words that the posting uses to describe the experiences or skills of the ideal candidate. If you believe you fit the job description, incorporate those exact words or phrases into your resume.

Another great way to find keywords is to research the company. Carefully read their mission, values and organizational culture. Consider and include in your resume qualifications that align with the company's vision, ideals, work environment and community.

2. Contextualize your keywords

Integrate your keywords into the rest of your resume. Most applicant tracking systems (ATS) prefer resumes that don't list one keyword after another, such as a skills section filled only with keywords. ATS

software is more likely to approve resumes that incorporate keywords throughout the text.

After defining your keywords, detail your skills or experiences related to them. For example, say your keywords are "motivated," "communication" and "photo editing." Instead of just listing these words on your resume, you can write bullet points related to specific work experiences that integrate these keywords, such as:

- "Management of phone calls, emails and other communication methods for the entire office."
- "Proficient in photo editing, both online and desktop programs."
- "Highly motivated to find employment at a dynamic and dedicated company."

3. Choose a file format that ATS can read

Many people save and send their resumes in PDF format, as this format is common and helps preserve document formatting. However, if you know or suspect that applicant tracking system (ATS) software may view your resume before the employer, save it in text format. ATS programs often have difficulty reading text in PDF files, as they may interpret it as a single large image rather than a text document.

If possible, save your resume through Microsoft Word as a .docx. A .docx is easily read by ATS and is the most likely to preserve your resume formatting. You can also save your resume in another text format, such as a .doc, .rtf or .txt. Only submit your resume as a PDF if the online portal or job posting specifies PDF as an accepted format.

4. Limit your unique formatting

Unique and professional formatting can sometimes help distinguish your resume among hiring managers. However, unique formatting often confuses ATS software and may cause the ATS to misread or ignore crucial information on your resume. Reduce the following aspects of your resume when submitting an application that you know or suspect ATS may scan: graphs, tables, charts, boxes, graphics, columns, animations, pictures, colored fonts or elements, and special characters such as an asterisk or backslash on the same line as your name.

5. Make your resume readable for ATS and employers

Present the information on your resume in a way that's easy for both ATS robots and human employers to understand. Choose a standard resume format, such as a chronological or functional format. Consider using a resume template to ensure that you include your most relevant qualifications logically and clearly.

6. Minimize the information in your header or footer

Limit how much you write in your resume's header or footer. Many people use a resume header or footer to include their contact information. While this can be a great way to format resumes reviewed by human professionals, some ATS programs have trouble reading the text inside headers and footers. Write your contact information in the body of your resume instead.

7. Customize your resume for each posting

Personalize your resume for every job you apply for. You can use the same basic template for each of your resumes, but try to customize different versions of your resume for each job application. Companies often program their ATS software to search for specific words or phrases found in their job posting, company values or mission statement. For every job you apply to, scan the description and

research the company to find their unique keywords. Include these in your resume to help ensure that your application passes through the ATS scan.

8. Incorporate details

Write details on your resume. More advanced ATS programs often search for specifics related to the position you're applying for, such as types of technology you've used or numerical data. Increase your chances of getting through the ATS scan by adding more details to your resume.

For example, say one of your bullet points about a previous job reads: "Helped customers regularly." Determine if you could add any further relevant and specific information to that statement. Here are a few ideas:

- "Helped an average of five customers an hour solve their technology problems."
- "Helped customers repair, test or troubleshoot their purchased devices."
- "Helped customers over the phone, by email and through live online chat."

9. Choose clear phrases

Use concise and direct language in your resume. Incorporating unique phrases in your resume can help human recruiters remember your application. However, ATS typically cannot understand unique phrasings, such as idioms, metaphors or puns. Choose straightforward words and phrases instead.

For example, your resume for human employers might use unique section headings, such as "find me here" or "where I've been." Change these headings to more standard phrases for ATS software, such as "contact information" and "work experiences."

10. Write out acronyms

Write out what an acronym or abbreviation stands for the first time you use it on your resume. If you include the word again in your resume later on, use only the acronym.

For example, if you know search engine optimization (SEO), write out search engine optimization the first time you mention this skill on your resume. If you discuss SEO later in your resume, you only need to use the abbreviation.

11. Test if your resume is scannable

See if ATS can read your resume before submitting your application. Make your resume into a plain text document and check the document for any unusual formatting. For example, look for headings that may have shifted into the middle of a section or characters that the plain text format cannot read. Compare the plain text version of your resume to the original to ensure that all the information is still there. If all the information in your plain text resume is present and formatted properly, then ATS software can successfully read your resume.

12. Keep online information up to date

Ensure that your information online aligns with the content of your resume. For example, any information about your jobs shared publicly on social media should match the work experience in your resume. More advanced ATS programs may gather research or check information about you online and compare it to your resume.

13. Submit your resume early

Send your job application by email or through a company's online portal as soon as possible. Some ATS programs only accept a certain number of applications before closing. Increase your chances of submitting your resume early by subscribing to email or text message job alerts.

14. Add a cover letter

If possible, include a cover letter in your job application. Most ATS programs don't scan cover letters. However, a cover letter can make your application more memorable to hiring managers and may help you bypass ATS software.

Address your cover letter to a specific person at the company. If you know the professional who created the job listing, address the letter to them. If the job posting doesn't specify a contact person, do some research and address your letter to the company's human resources representative, recruiter or the head of the department you're applying to.

Use your cover letter as an opportunity to elaborate on important bullet points from your resume, explain how you could help the department or company, draw further connections between your qualifications and the company's desired candidate, show your enthusiasm and passion for the position, and discuss unique skills or experiences that don't fit into a section on your resume.

15. Use keywords multiple times

Include your keywords multiple times. Your chances of passing ATS software may increase if you incorporate keywords into your resume several times. However, do your best not to use the keywords just to increase your keyword count. Figure out ways to integrate the keywords naturally into the text of your resume.

16. Select regular bullet points

Use standard bullet point designs. Many word processing software offers various designs for bullet points, such as squares, stars or checkmarks. Some of these designs can help get your resume noticed by recruiters or hiring managers. However, ATS programs often cannot interpret unique bullet points, so including them may cause the software to misread information on your resume. Use standard bullet points instead, such as solid circles or circular outlines.

17. Separate titles and names

Make sure that the formatting of your resume clearly distinguishes your name and job titles. If a professional title is too close to other information on your resume, ATS software may interpret all the information as part of the title.

When listing job titles for your past work experiences, for example, separate your job title from your dates of employment with a comma. If you include a professional title in your contact information, such as "freelance graphic designer," be sure to have that title appear on a separate line from your name.

18. (Bonus) Optimize overall presentation

Remember that the ATS is scanning resumes to find qualified applicants based on keywords from the job description. Use a simplified resume format and tailor your content to the role that you're applying for.

so that you can ensure that you qualify and also that an ATS and recruiters can see it too. Think quality over quantity in your job search, and always represent your qualifications honestly.

Please note that none of the companies mentioned in this article are affiliated with Indeed. The information on this site is provided as a courtesy and for informational purposes only. Indeed is not a career or legal advisor and does not guarantee job interviews or offers.